CHAPTER ONE

The Concept of After-Image and the Scopic Apprehension of the City

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Several years ago I coined the term "after-image" in an effort to express a concept that had emerged as the editors of the present volume were discussing new ways to approach the subject of cities from a broad cultural point of view.[1] A great deal of published work on cities deals with images (both pictorial and conceptual), modes of representation, and perceptual strategies, and this suggested a fresh approach that would take stock of this epistemological tradition and at the same time avoid at least some of the problems inherent in an unquestioned notion of imaginary representation.

Our approach differs from classic image-of-the-city studies not because it chooses iconoclasm over postmodern iconolatry, but because it takes stock of the limitations involved in a static or simply seriatim scrutiny of images. Because we were aware of these limitations and of those involved in merely critiquing the concept of image, we did not give in to the temptation, in an age of proliferating posts-, to add one more to the ever-expanding list. Instead we preferred to explore the semantic wealth of the prefix "after" in the context of visual metaphors and urban representations.[2]

Detached from the presumed transcendence implied by "post-," the hyphenated term "after-image" retains the full sense of its constituents as well as the meaning of the nonhyphenated form. It denotes a visual sensation that lingers after the stimulus that provoked it has disappeared, and opens the idea of "image" to a cluster of theoretical possibilities based on temporal displacement, sequentiality, supersession, and engagement. Unlike "post-image," however, the concept of after-image does not suggest that one transcends and leaves behind the imaginary. The image is fully

retained, but is now a temporalized, unstable, complex image brimming with the history of its production.[3]

A clarification is in order. The image is not to be conceived in a narrowly optic sense but in a larger visual one. We do not know the city only through our eyes and through the media: cartography, photography, film, virtuality. Even though the "material image" (an oxymoron) subtends much of what we know or think we know about cities, we always turn to our mental apparatus to grasp and decode the external organization of stimuli; we turn, that is, not only to our faculties of apprehension but also to the (private or public) imaginary within which the after-image is an image, but no longer an empirical one, a processed bit of knowledge that would be very difficult to isolate from more abstract forms of the image, such as the concept or the metaphor.

Perception psychology has shown that postperceptual processes are at work in fixing and storing images. The time elapsed between perception and decoding, and between retention and retrieval, is an eventful time. The term "eventful time" is redundant, of course, but the point should be clear: the image is not a timeless Platonic entity, nor is it a concurrence of presences linking the subject to the object. The retinal response, based on a physiological mechanism, is not a metaphor or an index but the very model for the formation and persistence of mental images. "How can we have failed to grasp," Paul Virilio asks, "that the discovery of retinal retention that made the development of Marey's chronotopography and the cinematography of the Lumière brothers possible, also propelled us into the totally different province of the mental retention of images?" (Virilio 60–61).

Between the prolepsis of the impression—a "fore-sight"—and the analepsis of recognition, seeing organizes, and, in a sense, creates, perception. Seeing, then, consists of the time intervening between impression and fixation, or rather, of the event or sum of events allowing us to focus on a fragment of the visual field. But since this activity begins in the past and fully holds that past in the present of vision, it comprises not only the memory function but also a subliminal harmonization of the differential moments in the visual take. In other words, seeing implies a certain tension within and a resolution of the image.

Once this is understood, image resolution can no longer be conceived spatially, through static terms and concepts, but must be seen temporally, as the provisional stabilization of visual effect through mental or technical editing. "Let's not forget, either," says Virilio, "that there is no such thing as 'fixed sight,' or that the physiology of sight depends on the eye's movements, which are simultaneously incessant and unconscious (motility) and constant and conscious (mobility)" (61).

The nonsynchronous occurrence of impression and perception can

also take another form, when the after-image involves temporal extrapolation. By this I mean that the formation of the image can produce a misadjustment of temporality through an illusory reversal of the cause-effect relation. The image, that is, may literally come *after* the event it represents, altering its documentary value. Under such circumstances it appears to follow the future perfect temporality of the *"postmodern"* as defined by Jean-François Lyotard: "The paradox of the future (post) anterior (modo)" (Lyotard 81), the time of what will have been.

We find an example of an after-image in this sense in the postmodern cult film *Blade Runner* (1982) by British director Ridley Scott. In the scene, Rachel (a female human simulacrum called a "Replicant") answers Deckard's suspicions of her counterfeit nature by appealing to her childhood memories. Deckard, who works as a Replicant-exterminating agent, refutes this subjective proof by pointing out that those memories were implanted into her genetically engineered body. The past that a Replicant can call forth, then, is a programmed synthesis of nonlived experience, or possibly a transplant of vicariously lived experiences, as Deckard suggests: "Those aren't your memories, they're someone else's."

The purpose of a synthetic past is to promote libidinal cathexes and subjective projection, thus making Replicants easy to control through the manipulation of their libidinal anchors. As Tyrell the Replicant builder remarks: "If we give them a past, we create a cushion or pillow for their emotions, and consequently, we can control them better." Visibly touched by the threat to her subjectivity, Rachel advances one last confirmation of her humanness: a photograph of herself as a child with her mother. What is interesting in this scene is not that images can be tinkered with but that, as a consequence, they reverse the testimonial order, designing memories to suit the affections. Whereas the documentary authority of photography was based on the synchronicity between the image and the event it "captured," the images of Replicants (and images as replicas) turn out to be postfactual, they come *after* the event they evoke without having witnessed it.

The scene is compelling insofar as it defines nonsynchronicity as the very "essence" of images. If they "speak" about anything, it is about the gap between themselves and their authentic other, about themselves as gap. Their act of signification is itself an index of the displacement of action from the event in itself to the event *in* the image. Through its own dynamic, the image, like the Replicants in Scott's film, is capable of fulfilling the requirements of the eventful. It fulfills them not by making something happen—although that possibility cannot be ruled out—but rather by making it necessary that something has already happened. Rachel's photograph is performative, establishing her past in Lyotard's postmodern fashion, as that which will have been by virtue of the image.

Scott's film establishes a similar relation between image and event through its proleptic viewing of a Los Angeles existing in 2019. The issue here is not that the film produces the city as a simulacrum on the same ontological level as its Replicants, but that the imagery is essentially rhetorical and nostalgic, that it yearns for a history not of the city but of city images that properly belong to the history of film. Scott himself declared that *Blade Runner* is "a 40-year-old film set forty years in the future" (quoted in Doel and Clarke 142). And Mike Davis, commenting on the film's failure to activate a vision of the real Los Angeles "as it socially and physically erodes into the 21st century," declares that *Blade Runner* "remains yet another edition of [a] core modernist vision . . . of the future metropolis as Monster Manhattan." Indeed, after one removes "the overlays of 'Yellow Peril' . . . and 'Noir' . . . as well as a lot of high-tech plumbing retrofitted to street-level urban decay, what remains is recognizably the same vista of urban gigantism that Fritz Lang celebrated in *Metropolis*" (Davis, "Beyond *Blade Runner*" 1–2; quoted in Doel and Clarke 145).

In this regard, it is immaterial whether *Blade Runner*, like Rachel's photograph, thereby creates a false genealogy, whether, that is, it merely "*appears* to reflect something of capitalism, subjectivity, history, and the real" as "so many false mirrors—so many hauntings or spectral manifestations," as Marcus A. Doel and David B. Clarke assert (146). Either as mirror or as false mirror, the image defines the event: what will have happened or what will simply appear to have happened reverses the logic of *post hoc propter hoc*. Through this reversal, causality is downgraded to sequentiality: the cause of the vision (the image) engenders an illusory sequence and a fake ontology: I show it, therefore it happened.

My own awareness of the inherent complexity and contradiction in the images we entertain about cities began many years ago. This can be best illustrated by referring to a city of which I have relatively little *direct* experience (which does not mean I have few or insignificant experiences of it). I underscore the word "direct" to suggest how problematic the notion is that one can have unmediated experiences of such thoroughly cultural realities as cities. More distinctly than any of the cities in which I have lived, Madrid is for me a mediated "place." I never set foot in it as long as it was "Franco's city." When I finally arrived there in the summer of 1976, I went to see, first, not the Plaza Mayor, the Castellana, or the Prado Museum, but the warped mirrors in the calle de Alvarez Gato. I had read about them in Valle-Inclán's expressionist play *Luces de Bohemia* (1924) and was not sure they would still be there. They intrigued me more than anything else in Madrid because they were the objectual metaphor or objective correlative for a new aesthetic, a new art of creating images: one that was developed theoretically in the process of producing a counterimage or, in our terms, an after-image of that very city.

The mirrors were, in fact, still in the alley, modest witnesses to an image that, like themselves, contained the residue of a spent gaze. By 1976 Madrid had perfected its image as the symbolic center of a sinister exercise of power, a power that was still discernible in the familiarity and, in some instances, in the devotion with which people spoke about Franco and his military aides in bars and cafés. Yet careful inspection of some still-inconspicuous details revealed to the outside observer that the city was ready to leap toward a new cultural image. In 1976 these two images met in a kind of interzone strongly imprinted with the past, but a past already worn around the edges. And it was at the edges that the dissolve was taking place. At the time, however, the two images remained separate and dissonant, as if reflected in the two warped mirrors in the calle de Alvarez Gato. Only much later did I realize that those images were complementary, not just because both partook of the same social imaginary, but because they were intimately related, two versions or moments in a lengthy and ongoing effort to determine the symbolic status of that "place."

The notion of urban image entails several assumptions. The first and most obvious is that the city is primarily a visual object, that it is grasped above all through sight ("La ville s'appréhende avant tout par le regard" [Bofill and Véron 127]). Another is that a synthetic faculty exists by means of which city dwellers convert their sensory impressions into functional eidetic representations of their environment. For those who share this hypothesis, "the image of the city can be grasped in its totality as a 'figure' in a differential relationship with a 'surrounding' " (Mazzoleni 293). Kevin Lynch, theorizing such an image-building faculty, posited a convergence between epistemic and everyday living practices. In hindsight, however, such a perspective seems naive, especially in reference to modern conurbations.

Before the development of the nineteenth-century metropolis, cities could be measured by walkers and grasped as visual totalities when observed from outside the limits of the urban area. The very structure of the city transmitted important information about the population's lifestyle and conditions, even though the city's symbolic dimension (still perceptible to the Renaissance observer) had gradually become unrecognizable. Today those inclusive images are no longer available, except as virtual compositions in the urban imaginary. As J. B. Jackson notes, "the image of the contemporary city, the sign or logo which all of us know how to interpret, is a blend of cartographic abstraction and aerial view" (Jackson 55).

The perceptual change does not mean simply that a previously dominant architectural image has been displaced by a more abstract aviator's view. A downward-looking, remote perspective has not taken the place of an upward-looking, more absorbed one. The mutation, rather, is that architecture has become obsolete as the sole or even primary medium for

visualizing the city. The image of the contemporary city is not only mediated by a variety of communications media but actually emerges from them. Increasingly, it is generated by the techniques of mechanical reproduction and manipulation in the service of urban marketers. One consequence of this appropriation is to further distance use and aesthetic values, a process that was already noticeable in the modernist city, and which gives rise to a semiotic dislocation in which, according to Kevin Robins, "the image of the city floats free from the 'reality' of the built environment" (306). As one critic of Barcelona's renovation pointed out in the mid-1980s, a large number of the spaces that were planned or reconverted were designed to be photographed (quoted in McDonogh 363).

While official discourse pandered to the need to respect and enhance the distinct life of the neighborhoods, much of the acclaim for the renovations undertaken by the socialist teams at city hall was an international response to the promotion of the planning and architectural work in glossy brochures, magazines, and lavishly illustrated books. Not only will the pictures retain their postmodern glamour longer than the buildings and city furnishings, but, as enduring dissatisfaction in certain districts suggests, the gap between experience and promotion, between those who collectively make up the city and use it and those responsible for its soaring image (and real estate prices), confirms the inadequacy of Lynch's idea of the city image as the meeting place for epistemic and everyday practices, or, in social terms, as the conjunction between the experience of residents and the goals of planners.

More fundamentally, comprehensive city images are no longer possible because, after the successive modern expansions and assimilations of neighboring municipalities, the metropolitan area has replaced the city. Where it still exists as a social and not just an administrative circumscription, the city can no longer be demarcated except, as Thomas Sieverts claims, through a collection of visually unobservable features. The new delimiting marks are arbitrary statistical thresholds regarding density of population, labor relations, the labor market, consumption patterns, rates of criminality, and so on (Sieverts 88). The totality once represented by the city image now reappears synthetically as an average, which can be graphically displayed but nonetheless remains an average image or, more exactly, the image of an average (Sieverts 94). Qualitative relations disappear from the picture; henceforth only easily quantifiable features are deemed relevant or even practicable by city planners, analysts, and authorities. What is left out constitutes a fundamental area of experience that was presupposed in Lynch's concept of imagibility: the area of direct observation by the participants in city life.

If quantitative relations fall within the purview of urban pragmatics and planning, the qualitative area associated with participatory consciousness

seems to partake of the poetic imaginary, which Bachelard linked to a condition of not knowing and to the piecemeal association of images (Bachelard xxix). In its freedom from cultural mediations and ordinary perception (xx), Bachelard's poetic image differs from city images and after-images. Nevertheless, it embodies a distinction between the totalizing images of planning and the composite images produced ad hoc by the anonymous agents of city life. Still, the distinction should not be conceived categorically as that between seeing and not seeing or image and nonimage. Michel de Certeau contrasts observation from the ground to the scopic power of the planning god, the perspective of urban ants to King Kong's perspective. It remains true nonetheless that grounded, participatory observation (however residual or anachronistic) invests the strivings for urban totalizations by those in power with a content. Observation, as Chris Jenks points out, "is no longer regarded as the empirical exercise of the optic senses" (145); yet this exercise remains a foundational metaphor for the subtler, because abstracter (and thus potentially more arbitrary) methods in modern sociocultural analysis.

Sight as metaphor sustains Certeau's anthropomorphic formulation of modern planning and control epistemologies. In a celebrated passage from *The Practice of Everyday Life,* he evokes the viewpoint from the top of the World Trade Center. Up there one is a voyeur, a nonparticipant. Distance from the street allows the viewer to "read" the city (but in which urban code and in relation to what urban textuality?) or, more properly, to look down on it in a thoroughly objectifying—scientific or semiological—way. As Certeau recognizes, "the fiction of knowledge is related to this lust to be a viewpoint and nothing more" (92). The distance of 1,370 feet above street level (a visual metaphor for the godlike distance of pure knowledge and now, as the events of September 11, 2001 have shown, for the terrorist's lethal emotional distance from his victims) transmutes the city into a semic surface, unrolls it like a map under the pressure of the panoramic view, and supports the fiction of readability, which, in Certeau's accurate phrase, "immobilizes [the city's] opaque mobility in a transparent text" (Certeau, *Practice* 92).

Immobile transparency of a text or message (but are texts truly immobile?) also defines the fully semiotized image that the concept of after-image calls into question. The modern city is still organized by the scopic drive that created the medieval and Renaissance perspectival representations, but the desire to immobilize the city in an encompassing image is contested by a multiplicity of participatory viewpoints, which amount to so many perspectives. Certeau, who is clearly aware of this particularity, also declares: "The panorama-city is a 'theoretical' (that is, visual) simulacrum, in short a picture, whose condition of possibility is an oblivion and a misunderstanding of practices" (*Practice* 93).

Certeau's theoretical simulacrum refers to an actual technology for the spectacularization of the city and is therefore a belated theoretical deployment of the effects produced by a new visual contrivance. In 1791 Robert Barker inaugurated a sensational 360-degree painting medium, the panorama, which he introduced to the public in Leicester Square in London. While the pseudo-Greek term "panorama" added scientific glamour to the invention, its original name, "View-at-a-Glance," suggested the speed and inclusiveness of the gaze experienced in the panorama—in other words, the spectator's control over the object on display, an object which, in that first showing as in most later programs, was a cityscape. The appeal of the simulacrum lay, obviously, in its spectacular effect, due in large part to the initial shock of immediacy and also to the reversal of inside and outside, whereby the city appeared spread out inside a building. Yet the publicity stressed above all the power of the illusion to substitute itself for the referent and thus to dispense with the actual experience of place.

When Barker's panorama opened in the autumn of 1791, the advertisement for the "view-at-a-glance of the Cities of London and Westminster" promised visitors they would be "deceived as to suppose themselves on the Albion Mills from which the view was taken" (D'Arcy Wood 112). Since the simulated view was virtually the same as the original, there was no need to position oneself at the physical site to enjoy the perspective. After visiting Pierre Prévost's Panorama of Athens, shown in Paris in 1821, Quatremère de Quincy declared: "The precious remains of antiquity of the city were rendered with a verisimilitude that seemed to dispense with the need to actually see the originals" (quoted in D'Arcy Wood 103).

Certeau can contrast the panoramic view to the obliterated practices *in* the city, and especially, to walking, because practices, the assorted social forms of dealing with objects and with the world as object, are superseded in the illusion of instant availability to the eye. Since the first of all practices is to physically go to meet the object, the panorama spectator's deception regarding location implied not only the disappearance of the object (the vanishing of the city into its image) but also the inauguration of a social dysfunction. Henceforth, the acting subject is seduced into passively consuming a synecdochic relation to the fetishized environment. The panorama induces voyeurism as the characteristically modern approach to the city; *flânerie,* so often invoked in connection to movement in the street, is, in view of the flâneur's objective detachment in his ritual scopism, less a practice than a liturgy of social self-removal (from the crowd and everything it stands for) and control through the eye—in short, a means of spectacularizing the social world while dispensing with the need to acknowledge one's position in it.

It is precisely practices that the concept of after-image evokes, by em-

phasizing the tension-ridden, mutation-oriented, and temporally determined character of an otherwise flat and static iconic construction. By connecting theory with its etymon "viewing," Certeau implicitly concedes the static nature of theoretical discourse. Theory hankers after representation. Even if it strenuously avoids mimetic strategies, it operates by stabilizing and imaging a shifting reality. In M. Christine Boyer's words, "Every discourse sets up a spatial order, a frozen image that captures the manner in which the transitory present is perceived. Momentarily arresting disruptive and energetic forces, representational forms become succinct records of what we consider to be present reality. These aesthetic models transform our sense of the real, for the image of the city is an abstracted concept, an imaginary constructed form" (32).

Visual simulacrum and frozen image, however, are not inescapably linked to inscrutability and blindness. The experience of cities, in other words, need not be expressed by the dialectic between removed demiurgic seeing and eyeless involvement. What can one make, then, of Certeau's assertion that practices are embedded in an opaque atmosphere far below the threshold of visibility? How much credit should we lend to the claim that the practices constituting the city are blind, or that the networks woven by those practices do not presuppose an author or spectators and are themselves incongruous with representation? (Certeau, *Practice* 93) Are these anything but concessions to a poststructuralist predilection for the fragmentary, the disturbing, the incomprehensible? Do they amount to more than a radicalization of the Marxist idea of a false consciousness (which reads, but necessarily in the wrong code) and of the psychoanalytical motif of an instinctual language (which not only lacks a univocal interpretive science but also a detached, transference-free analyst)?

I would say yes. In the passage under consideration, Certeau provides an eloquent description of the image-forming and image-displacing processes. The spatial recital of previsual activities in the interstices of the city skyline serves as a description for the inter- and suprasubjective processes of image formation. Certeau's almighty seer from above is obviously a metaphor for the detached contemplation of the planner who turns the city into a spectacle based on the concealment of practices. The events of September 11, however, have shown how sudden flares can emerge from the obscure world of practices and turn the city into a spectacle of its own disappearance (see chap. 5). By yielding the most stunning, the most unpredictable images, these bursts of eradicating energy momentarily expose what planning and the social order had objectified in the seeming atemporality of the image. What scopic power conceals—and what the terrorist's fleeting appropriation of that privileged viewpoint on the city reveals—is, above all, the history of the production of its images.

As Hubert Damisch observes, bird's-eye views long preceded the invention of the airplane, confounding the image of the city with its relief map. But it was in the nineteenth century that architects multiplied panoramic views and opened perspectives in the core of the old cities. "It is as though, at the moment when the great city, the metropolis, the *Grossstadt*, was beginning to call for an image of agglomeration other than a strictly architectural one, it seemed indispensable to preserve its visibility" (Damisch 12). Indeed, it would seem that the very images in which the modern city has sought to recognize itself were visual rejoinders to a newly forming image that had to be kept below the threshold of visibility, at the level of the opaque experience Certeau calls practices. In nineteenth-century Paris, the newly perfected camera made the ritual of "walking in the city" a self-conscious representation on Haussmann's new perspectival stage (Burgin 14). Walking on the boulevards lost the opacity of traditional street-level mobility in favor of a self-seeing participation in the production of the vanishing point. Still, could the restrictions on the use of the camera in public places—finally lifted in 1890—have obeyed a logic of concealment? Might they have been intended to keep from public recognition, and thus from the city's image, those aspects that Haussmann's perspectivism helped obscure and displace? In practice, the newfangled image of Paris resulted from a power differential among urban players, all with stakes in a risky game of visibility/invisibility.

We must be careful, however, not to anthropomorphize the city and invest it with mythical self-reflexivity. The city does not look upon itself; it does not manage its images with the fabled intelligence and blind rationality of the market. There is no invisible visibility, no remote urban god responsible for the formation of city images. There is, however, as James Donald notes, a historically specific mode of seeing that arises with cities and allows us to conceive of the city as "a structure of visibility" (Donald, "The City" 92). The city produces novel modes of perception, poetic metaphors, and conceptual categories, and is, therefore, deeply implicated in the epistemology of the image. The concept of after-image could only have emerged in an environment where, in Georg Simmel's memorable words, "the rapid telescoping of changing images" (325) forces the mind not only to adapt to the accelerating changes but also to reflect on change itself, on the relation between the images and temporality.

For a long time, it has been generally believed that the image is a stable representation, and one, moreover, that offers itself up to spontaneous decoding or that requires no decoding (the case of radical mimesis). The dictum, "a picture is worth more than a thousand words," reveals as much about the cultural bias in favor of visual "eloquence" as it does about the widespread sense that the power of the image does not depend on meaning but on its capacity to expose. On the other hand, attention to historic-

ity, to process, and to diegesis brings out the relevance of the image, raising the question of whether it was ever an adequate means for the cognitive apprehension of the city. Skeptical about the efficacy of the image, Richard Sennett points out that the principle of mutation underlying urban processes drains the meaning from unchanging representations of a place (219). Sennett's remark, warranted by the accelerated pace of change in today's urban environment, brings to the fore ideas that were implicit in the observations of early sociologists. Modernity and its urban stage, the metropolis, featured two new qualities: abstractness and an accelerated rhythm of encounters. A desire to understand these new aspects led to sophisticated analyses of the relations between mobile perception and the exposure of realities ordinarily hidden to the static viewpoint.

Around 1900 it became clear that "the image would have to incorporate the element of temporality, a sense not only of newness but also of accelerated rhythm. The multiplication of perspectives [by the cubists] was a way of acknowledging the existence of simultaneous realities and also the condensation and intensification of time in the street, the automobile and the train" (Donald, "The City" 84). With the rise of the dynamic image and of images-in-succession in film, the city manifested itself as a process with the force of self-revelation. In Benjamin's characteristically sculpted phrase, "by the dynamite of the tenth of a second," film burst open the buildings, rooms, and streets of metropolitan reality, expanding their dimensions by temporally extending the subject's perceptions of ordinary reality ("The Work of Art" 236).

The symphony films of the 1920s multiplied perspectives, subjecting them to the rhythm of urban activities while vastly enlarging the field of perception for the city dweller. Furthermore, the emphasis on machinery and the technical conditioning of daily routines seemed to refute Benjamin's observation that film's mimetic illusion depends on the erasure of the technological infrastructure subtending modern reality and its images ("The Work of Art" 233). With the development of montage, it became clear that the semantic gunpowder of the image flared up at contact with other images, that the power of an image to signify depended on the other images with which it came in contact and on the speed of the transition from one image to the next. Film not only temporalized the photograph, subjecting it to rhythm; more important, it turned the still photograph into a site for dialectical encounters.

It was film, more than Proust's *mémoire involontaire* (which often gets the credit), that inspired Benjamin's "dialectical image," that is, an image that, according to Graeme Gilloch, "seeks to capture historical movement, the changing visage of the metropolis in a textual freeze-frame" (114). Certainly, the concept is linked to forgetfulness and to recovery, or, in more explicitly Freudian terms, to repression and disclosure. In "The

Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," Benjamin emphasized alienated visual memory, but he did so in relation to the discoveries of the camera. Like the stream of memories unlocked by Proust's madeleine, in cinema a whole chain of previously inaccessible images could be triggered by an external object that aided the body's sensorium. "The camera," wrote Benjamin, "introduces us to unconscious optics as does psychoanalysis to unconscious impulses" ("The Work of Art" 237). But it was film's articulation of vision in the movement between different stills that produced a new form of awareness in the instant of the object's vanishing.

This cinematic rendering of urban life draws on Simmel's 1903 essay, "The Metropolis and Mental Life." Simmel anticipated the idea that intensified flows of stimuli, typical of the environment of the modern city, can overwhelm the human sensorium. "Man," said Simmel, "is a creature whose existence is dependent on differences, i.e., his mind is stimulated by the difference between present impressions and those which have preceded" (325). Perception and the meaning of the objects perceived were seen to depend more on the transitions between impressions than on the discreet impressions themselves. But impressions could be too intense and, above all, too densely packed and too diverse to be smoothly integrated into consciousness. "The rapid telescoping of changing images, pronounced differences within what is grasped at a single glance, and the unexpectedness of violent stimuli" (325) demanded the development of new strategies of perception.

Years later, Benjamin would consider those strategies formally established by film (Donald, *Imagining* 74). For him, film extended the range of the visible, just as the city did for Simmel. Unsurprisingly, it was the city that Benjamin identified as the privileged stage for the operation of film, so that the "far-flung ruins and debris" of the old visual world exploded by the camera were in effect the fragments of "our taverns and our metropolitan streets, our offices and furnished rooms, our railroad stations and our factories" ("The Work of Art" 236). In short, those debris were fragments of a closed and static image that film had forced open as an "unexpected field of action" ("The Work of Art" 236).

Benjamin was exploring ways for the historian to shake the accumulated and fossilized memories of the past. The historical materialist was engaged in "blasting open" history's continuum ("Theses" 262), just as the camera "burst asunder" the "prison-world" of traditional city images ("The Work of Art" 236). Through its systematic use of the shock experience produced by the modern metropolis and the arrival of new technologies of motion (Schivelbusch, *The Railway Journey* 160), film was able to create discontinuities in perception that favored attention to previously unremarked details, relations, or objects. It provided an epistemic model

for the fleeting, the marginal, and the suppressed, which could then reappear under pressure from the tension packed in the moment of attention—what Benjamin calls the "moment of danger," in the "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (255). It is in this text that he asserts most explicitly the instability of the image, its resemblance to a trace: "The true picture of the past flits by. The past can be seized only as an image which flashes up at the instant when it can be recognized and is never seen again" (255). The past, that is, cannot be grasped or retained; it appears only in the recognition of its disappearance, as an image that comes in its own wake: an after-image. Such an image takes shape momentarily in the counterreflection with which the historical materialist "brush[es] history against the grain" and, in doing so, redeems the genuine historical image from the static images that make up the continuum of history into which the oppressor inscribes his relation to the past ("Theses" 257).

A century of visual education in the intrinsic dynamism of images should have dispelled the pictorial conventions that have organized the apprehension of cities in the West. But, as Grady Clay points out, recent books on cities continue to deal with their subject in the obsolete terms of order and unity, scale and space, light and shadow, and color and texture, which no longer respond to contemporary urban reality (29). Our way of looking, he claims, is culturally conditioned; it responds to centuries-old conventions that cause us to apprehend the familiar at the expense of all that escapes established ways of looking. We are "stuck to an old constraint," which holds our perceptions at an earlier historical stage (23). Of these premodern conventions, he finds perspectivism the most pervasive; it confines the world in "a kind of tunnel vision" (23). The claim may or may not be true (cubism and futurism, for example, challenged the monoperspectival tradition), but it is indisputable that our long-ingrained pictorial mode of looking supports the idea of stable images, and of a perceiving subject who acts as a pivot for the world's symmetry and intrinsic order.

Images that are controlled by a univocal perspective are steadfast and ahistorical. They are fertile ground for the rhetoricity that Roland Barthes associated with ideological messages. Incidentally, it is the assumption of a stable visual order—an order that would allow the reliable coding of images—that has given rise to the idea of the city as text, an idea that, if it has any sense at all, presupposes a stable meaning that can be accessed at different times by a community of "readers."

Barthes raises urgent questions about the semantic status of the image: "How does meaning get into the image? Where does it end? And if it ends, what is there *beyond*?" ("Rhetoric of the Image" 32). In attempting to answer these questions, he finds that the image contains a triad of messages, that it deploys a threefold sphere of communication. The first of these

messages is explicitly linguistic. In the case of the city, it would include all linguistic signs, from neon advertisements to noniconic traffic signs, and the whole array of inviting, tempting, informing, forbidding, or warning messages that keep step with a walker's meandering path through a city. In this category are the journalistic, the literary, the political, the artistic, the economicist, and all texts generated by and addressed to the city as a community of textually initiated residents. At this level, the image is anchored by the linguistic message, which selects some signifieds and excludes others. In contrast, the two messages that arise at the iconic level constitute the image proper.

The second and third messages, Barthes argues, are not discreet and can only be distinguished analytically. One refers us to the image as coded icon and the other to the same image as uncoded, that is, to the confusion of the object with its image in naive perception. Insofar as images function ideologically, they aim to establish themselves at this third level of the message, pretending to be message-free, or rather, to be their own message. Ideological images seem to be fragments of nature that can be perceptually appropriated without reference to any given code. It is this lack of coding or, more exactly, an automatic decoding below the threshold of awareness, that allows images to disguise intentionality and pass for universal statements of fact.

In an important sense, images depend on a reflexive doubling of perception; they depend, that is, on an awareness of the ontological gap between perception and representation. As W. J. T. Mitchell remarks, "an image cannot be seen *as such* without a paradoxical trick of consciousness, an ability to see something as 'there' and 'not there' at the same time" (17). Implicit in this trick is an answer to Barthes's question: "What is beyond the image?" Once it is understood, the trompe l'oeil effect intrinsic to every image discloses the fact that the image is *always already* beyond itself. It can only be grasped in the absence (and in the awareness of the absence) of a referent: object, idea, emotion, or, in short, the meaning it would re-present. In other words, an image is always *after* itself, in the sense that it tries to catch up to its referent, but also in the sense that a gap, whether physical, psychological, or cultural (or a combination of all three), always separates the sensation from its resolution and verification. Through this gap, meanings enter (or come out of) the image by virtue of a process of hermeneutic amplification. Such a process is often unreflective. Acculturated interpretive dispositions and previously internalized cognitive patterns are fired by the image, which is thus connoted, turned into a visual aid for meanings that precede it in the social field.

The gap between naive and acculturated perception has an analytical correlative in the concept of after-image, since the latter opens a temporal hiatus within the image that is more than the neutral delay associated with

retinal retention. Implicit in many studies about the cultural production of images is the assumption that cultural tinkering affects merely the ideologizable components of visuality, such as viewpoint or interpretation, while the images themselves are the optical resolution (and thus the objective presence) of that which is "sighted." In contrast, the concept of after-image opens a space for reflection not just on the cultural mediation of what is perceived but on the mnemonic character of the image, on its intervisuality. Such a space cannot be sutured by referring to the given character of the visual, nor by a hermeneutics that would naturalize (and neutralize) the relations between figure and discourse. If, as Mitchell says, "the image is the sign that pretends not to be a sign," and the word is "its 'other' " (43), then it follows that the dichotomy can, and often will, be enlisted to release the tension between the two components in favor of the illusion that the image, and the image alone, can retrieve the univocal truth of nature; or conversely, that it can restore us to the perceptual paradise where (Adamic) naming was redundant, since it merged with the fullness of the entities named.

To Barthes's question, "how does meaning enter into the image?" we can reply without hesitation: by importing time, consciousness, and history into its formal patterns. And perhaps guilt as well, the weight of culturally accumulated violence. The image, in any case, is never univocal. All images are, as Barthes declares, polysemous. Under the ice block of signifiers flows a throng of signifieds, some of which are hermeneutically netted while others swim past the conventional nets of meaning ("Rhetoric of the Image" 39). Furthermore, images brim with the history of their own production and with the conflicts and traumas of their emergence. The prefix "after-" has a slight connotation of exhaustion and spent energies, a touch of "aftermath," "the day after," or even, "after the battle." Beyond the commonplace that images provoke skepticism and thus a conflict of interpretations (which are in fact a form of verbal supplement), the concept of after-image uncovers a previous (and precariously settled) conflict of intentions.

As used in this book, the term "after-image" applies to the interpretation of both visual and linguistic messages, thus implicating the image in the postvisual process of cultural extension and decoding. Whether these messages are deemed ancillary to the phenomenological image or intrinsic to the symbolic status of images, whether they are strictly perceptual or installed in a textual imaginary, they are always coded, always culturally mediated. Much of the thematic material in this book includes not only discursive references to images in so-called visual media but also linguistic images of the city. Hence the question arises: does attention to the text elide the iconic status of the image? Does the textualization of the image demand its metaphorization? In other words, are linguistic images only

rhetorical and not real? I would claim that this is not the case, and for good reason, namely, because the notion of "real images" is rendered suspect by the intrinsic rhetoricity of the image and by the after-image status of decoded visual messages. While the media shape images differently depending on the technologies employed, the borderline between empirical reality and rhetoricity is as thin as that between Barthes's second and third messages within the image's range of communication.

If we now turn to the city, it becomes easy to discern that the textual dimension of the after-image underlies, and in a crucial sense, constitutes, the information structure of urban icons. The text ought not to be omitted (in a strict sense, it cannot be) from the analysis of modern after-images, for the important reason that purely sensorial, language-free icons are unavailable in a modern urban context. As Barthes reminds us, "in order to find images without words, it is doubtless necessary to go back to partially illiterate societies, to a sort of pictographic state of the image" ("Rhetoric of the Image" 38). The "pure image" or the resolutely "material image" yearns for a premodern state of innocence, as "imaginary" for preindustrial societies (consider, for example, the doubly coded—scripturally and pictographically—postCortesian Mexican codex Mendoza which combines pre-Colombian techniques such as the ideogram with text in Spanish) as it is for modern urban culture. In this anthropological sense as well, our images are most decidedly after-images, images fallen from the paradise of sensorial candor and semantic immediacy.

Barthes distinguished two functions in the linguistic component of the image: anchorage and relay. Anchorage directs the receiver's attention toward a preempted meaning; it preselects the signifieds that will become available. Through this function, the text controls the consumption of the image, cordoning off potentially destabilizing readings and favoring semantic permanence. Relay is a function of complementarity between text and icon: "The words, in the same way as the images, are fragments of a more general syntagm and the unity of the message is realized at a higher level, that of the story, the anecdote, the diegesis" ("Rhetoric of the Image" 41). In relay the accent falls on temporality and narrative tension, as meaning travels like a current along the sytagma while negotiating the status of the image. Although Barthes acknowledged that both anchorage and relay can be active within the same icon, he considered the prevalence of one or the other decisive in defining the character and uses of a particular image. Thus, anchorage is typical of press photographs and advertisements, while relay is found in comic strips and, above all, in film, where dialogue does not comment on the images but introduces an extrinsic semantic dimension that is nonetheless inseparable from the movement of the photograms.

These two functions of the linguistic component are at work in the

after-image. Cultural conventions depend on anchorage to promote the fixity of the image and, at their limit, to conceal the presence of the controlling text. Anchorage sustains the illusion by satisfying ingrained expectations; thus it helps conceal the synthetic character of the image. The image of a city, for example, is anchored in our general assumptions and limited knowledge about that city; or, in the case of cities we know well, it rests on hegemonic meanings that, because they have been successfully socialized, seem more legitimate than privately acquired ones. Hence, even if the experience of a city acquired through practices such as walking produces not a unified image but a series of images linked by a movement that is as contingent as the perspectives it yields, Lynch's observation remains true to some extent: city dwellers and visitors strive to compose a synthetic image merging the disparate fragments of their experience, and this will to make an overall meaning often gives rise to a manipulation of the visual order to produce images for consumption.

If they are to override our private memories of segmented space and juxtaposed urban fragments, such synthetic wholes must be anchored in widely accepted ideas. At the same time, these ideas must not call attention to themselves or their role as a framing device if the totalization they foster is to get the better of our perceptual wisdom. According to Barthes, images are structured around a set of connotative relations that stand for culture and a denotative syntagma that inserts the image into nature ("Rhetoric of the Image" 51). It is easy to recognize the two conventionally structuralist chains of linguistic relations in this dyad; but, in spite of its conventionality, this model of "ideological looking" may prove useful for disclosing the tensions repressed within stabilized or naturalized images, those which, according to Wittgenstein, hold us captive by virtue of their linguistic embeddedness (48).

The inexorable repetition of a picture tangled up in linguistic signification (and in the allure of mechanical reproducibility) is illustrated by the early history of print. Discussing the information value of pictures, E.H. Gombrich explains that medieval and Renaissance drawings were unconcerned with the relation between image and caption. In Hartmann Schedel's *Nuremberg Chronicle,* a book graced with woodcuts by Dürer's teacher Wolgemut, an image of a medieval city is used repeatedly with different captions to represent Damascus, Ferrara, Milan, and Mantua. Gombrich comments: "Unless we are prepared to believe these cities were as indistinguishable from one another as their suburbs may be today, we must conclude that neither the publisher nor the public minded whether the captions told the truth. All they were expected to do was to bring home to the reader that these names stood for cities" (69). It would seem that, in early print culture, artists and their audiences were indifferent to the relation between the linguistic and iconic levels of the

image. What counted was the plausibility of the image rather than its specificity. Unlike today's victim of urban advertising, the medieval reader would have been fully aware of the arbitrary link between image and text. In a curious nominalist turn the caption or nomenclator, not the idealized image, rendered the referent specific. The caption, in other words, did not function as an identifying tag; on the contrary, it was the picture that gave conceptual content—that of "cityness"—to an otherwise meaningless name. Like a road sign, or like an icon on a tourist map, the image functioned as a universal coding device, oblivious to the peculiarities of the actual site.

One reason for this absolute supremacy of anchorage may be that, as Gombrich points out, detailed pictures and a firsthand acquaintance with different cities were still rare in the Renaissance (68). Anchored in a culturally familiar topography, the city image served the purpose of categorical representation, controlling, through abstraction, the scope of the referents denoted by different captions. In this way, the picture contained the potentially boundless range of connotations of the linguistic message.

Notwithstanding its literalism, the image of the city presented by Schedel's "Nuremberg Chronicle" did not constitute a denoted image in Barthes's sense, and for a reason diametrically opposed to his explanation. According to Barthes, it is unlikely that "readers" will remain at the literal level of signification because "everyone from a real society always disposes of a knowledge superior to the merely anthropological and perceives more than just the letter" ("Rhetoric of the Image" 42). Yet, as we have seen, the earliest printed icons of cities were dutifully literal, to the point of taking over the denotative function entrusted to their captions. Most people's knowledge of foreign cities did not rise above the information transmitted by the image qua image. In order to raise the stakes of connotation and to reintroduce into the image the discontinuities between sign and meaning, readers had to become travelers, had to test images against the touchstone of their own experience. In other words, they had to ground their recognition of cities in their own experience of motion and contingency.

That condition of *having-been-there*, which Barthes considered specific to the photograph ("Rhetoric of the Image" 44), eventually led to the destruction of the aura and, along with it, of the belief in "true icons." Originally a guarantee of the authenticity of the visual citation of reality, having-been-there gave way to the synthetic illusion of presence and the annihilation of distance (and consequently, of time as well), which Benjamin discerned as the deepest desire of the masses. In due course, the iconoclasm of modernity formalized its skepticism toward representation by inventing semiology. At the same time, however, modern skepsis and the attendant requirement of *having-been-there* gave birth to realism, the il-

lusion that images are, if not presences, at least documents (from Latin *docere*, to teach, to show, related to the Greek *dokein*, to appear, to seem). It is an illusion induced by a technically contrived overlap of present(ed) meaning and witnessed meaning—meaning procured by spatiotemporal displacement, by *going there* or *having-been-there.*

The spatiotemporal displacement implicit in the *having-been-there* of realistic images exposes *in nuce* the workings of the prefix "after-" at the heart of the image. With the rise of realism, images no longer usurped the denotative function of captions, but rather sought to complement it, supplying, along with a plethora of referential detail, information about their own aesthetic status. Thus, they replaced auratic presence with potentially endless strings of visual allusions intended to guarantee the faithfulness of the image to its referent. With the rise of the connoted image (and realism proved to be the strongest possible connoter), the coding and decoding of the messages became more laborious, since connoted images stress the relay function, subordinating linguistic and visual semes to higher units of signification.

One way of achieving this was for the semes to act as morphological stimuli encouraging the articulation of more complex meanings. Subordinating the units of signification into larger connoted structures was paramount in the development of realism. As Gombrich points out, it is not wealth of detail that produces the mimetic effect, since the amount of information packed into the picture may actually hinder its illusory power. Mimesis is achieved less by overstatement than by the painter's capacity to enlist the viewer's projective faculties (221). Realism is always connoted; it rests on the beholder's willingness to replace sensory impressions with information originating at the eidetic level. In Barthes's terms, with the emergence of realism information became "costlier," more demanding.

Simultaneously, with the sharpening of the gaze, the image became open to self-reflexivity and self-supersession, inescapably so because, under the increasingly semiotic conditions of European culture, the image was prey to an ever more acute consciousness of its inadequacy as a facsimile. Gradually, this self-induced "unhappiness of the image" pushed realism to ever greater feats of precision, leading eventually to its self-defeat through the systematic frustration of its conventions. The hopeless race against the referent quickened the obsolescence of images, contributing to their proliferation and incessant replacement and to a heightened sense of their historicity.

By "self-supersession" and "incessant replacement" I do not mean—at least not primarily—the different readings to which the image is susceptible by virtue of the various forms of knowledge that can be brought to bear on its interpretation. I refer, rather, to the destabilization caused by

these very forms of knowledge. The image was destabilized when lexicons were multiplied and an ever greater competence was required to apprehend the visual message. Under these conditions, images were increasingly surrogates for other images, and the accelerating tempo of dislocation made the transference of meaning perceptible not just between but also within images. Even so, images often endure beyond their lifespan, creating the impression that the historical course of an image is blazed by the previous images that track on its tail. Such optical relics invade the range of their epigones, causing a perceptual overlap and corresponding interpretive tensions. This loitering of the image, the delayed effect caused by its disappearance, is evidence that images spawn, engage with, discipline, and combat one another.

Claiming that the denotative syntagma was responsible for naturalizing the rhetoric of the image, Barthes defined that rhetoric as "the signifying aspect of ideology" ("Rhetoric of the Image" 49). One could also describe this naturalizing mechanism as the takeover of denotation by the cultural (connoted) elements of the image, a process we saw naively (but not innocently) at work in Schedel's "Nuremberg Chronicle." Less naively, denotation was again overlaid with rhetorical codes when cinema produced city images. Here, however, the effects were the opposite of those achieved by the Renaissance woodcuts. Fritz Lang's image of "Metropolis" may have been inspired by New York, but, as Siegfried Kracauer reminds us, it was produced in the studio by the Shuftan process, using small models to represent massive architectural forms (*From Caligari* 149). Rhetoric was eminently at work in turning allusion into illusion.

Like Wolgemut some four centuries earlier, Lang designed a city inspired by an idea of what a contemporary city looked or should look like, but, unlike his predecessor, he did not match this model to any given city. Abstaining from making mimetic claims and giving up topographic references, he futurized the image, placing it squarely in the realm of possibility. With its U.S. skyline, its baroque pleasure gardens, its Gothic cathedral, and its early Christian catacombs, Metropolis is as reminiscent of dadaist photomontages and of the industrial and urban landscape paintings of *Neue Sachlichkeit* (Huyssen 67–68) as it is of an unworldly city (Telotte 51).

By neutralizing and rendering anachronistic the embedded preindustrial images through a sleek technological *Aufhebung*, Metropolis furnished capitalism with the urban image of its bogus universality. Seduced by this non-place (history and crises are, as we know, pushed down into the catacombs), planners have since disseminated its image over the entire surface of the world. Supported by the master narrative of modernity, Metropolis appropriated the captions of actual topographic locations,

which, unlike the cities denoted by Wolgemut's woodcuts, could now be readily tested for agreement between image and referent.

Shall we conclude, then, that the non-place is the contemporary "caption" for city after-images? There is some justification for this conclusion. The non-place not only depletes the connotative resources of the referent, thus revalidating the purpose of the early Renaissance image; it also "sublates" the historicity of the city into the image of the so-called global city: the delocalized, dis-located after-city. As Marc Augé defines it, the non-place is not so much the lack of place as its negation, a kind of antiplace. Whereas place is historical and concerned with identity—both are attributes of early modernity—the non-place has nothing to do with topographic temporalities and specificities. It is an outgrowth of supermodernity (Augé, *Non-Places* 77–78). These new spaces of global intercourse are defined not by the relations they structure, or rather fail to structure, but by their instrumentality and the ends they serve: travel, transit, commerce, administration, leisure. Unlike places, which build the webs of the social, non-places create "solitary contractuality" (*Non-Places* 94). Of special interest is Augé's remark that place "is never completely erased," while the non-place "is never totally completed." One supervenes the other and wrests its meaning or nonmeaning from the previously existing symbolic determinations. In fact, says Augé, "they are like palimpsests on which the scrambled game of identity and relations is ceaselessly rewritten" (*Non-Places* 79).

If we seek to replace the textual metaphor of the palimpsest with a visual one, we immediately come upon the after-image: graphic superimposition on the one hand, but, on the other, preservation of the occluded image, which is and is not there, which is neutralized by supervening images but also determines them just as a background determines its figure. The after-image refers to an optic realm where outlines and relations are ceaselessly debated and hierarchies of meaning reversed. Thus, the proliferation of non-places stimulates the fabrication of place, a sort of city camp in the era of telecommunications and the high-speed travel that guts the inner life of cities and turns mid-sized towns into casual stopping areas along the routes by which we desert historical places. Augé explains: "Every town or village not of recent origin lays public claim to its history, displaying it to the passing motorist on a series of signboards which add up to a sort of 'business card.' Making the historical context explicit in this way, which in fact is quite a recent practice, coincides with a reorganization of space (the creation of bypasses and main motorway routes avoiding towns) that tends, inversely, to short-circuit the historical context by avoiding the monuments that embody it" (*Non-Places* 68). As Augé remarks, this touristic strategy is effective only to the degree that motorists

have a taste for history and for rooted identities, a taste he claims has become a distinctive French trait over the past twenty years, that is, over the period of expansion of the European non-places of supermodernity.

In Augé's account of newly emerging signs of local identity, it is possible to discern the reappearance of the Renaissance practice of invoking urban specificity through the caption, while dissolving that specificity in figurative homology. Today, as non-places multiply, the images of disappearing places must be advertised—and semioticized—to be perceived at all. The consequence of resemiotization is, paradoxically, to reinscribe the palimpsest, creating a visual overlay that calls into question the correlation between locality and authenticity. From now on, the historical imagination is stimulated by quotation—that is, by reference to the traces of that which can no longer be retrieved. Genuine monuments, and sometimes counterfeit or reconstructed ones, are consumed as so many tokens of the past, but, just as no reader of the "Nuremberg Chronicle" became any wiser about what Damascus, Ferrara, Milan, or Mantua *really* looked like, so today's cultural tourist, having plunged into history, gets back on the road without the promised experience of authenticity. As Augé puts it, "a gap is opened up between the landscape's present and the past to which it alludes" (*Non-Places* 69).

The temporal dislocation of places can also be expressed as a failure of denotation, as a breakdown of the narratives that naturalize the image of place. More positively, it might be seen as a resistance to the commodification that historical places display, paradoxically, through their imperviousness to the images of themselves produced by heritage promoters. "The sites from which every blink of an image is extracted," says McKenzie Wark, "are a reservoir of past events. . . . Sites like the Brandenburger Gate and the Potsdamer Platz are story accumulators, storage sites for stories about events that can never totally be commodified, packaged, and sold" (77). By pitting memory against the image, historical places upset every effort to freeze meaning in space. Memory is strongly connoted, and connotation opens a temporal gap in the surface of even the sleekest of images. Rushing in through this gap, stories and, above all, the story of the production of the image burst into the image. That gap is signified by the hyphen in the term "after-image." More a semantic placeholder than a place, the hyphen also expresses the gap in the after-image, itself a non-place, but one that re-places the image, restores it to place by infusing it with time and change.